

the alter ego of most husbands, especially young men. We have created a social environment where even as early as high school, status among males is determined in great part by the kind of car they drive. It's a small wonder then that when men have their own families, the same values carry over. They're going to select a car that reflects where they want to be financially, not necessarily where they are.

The result is an excessive percentage of a young family's income being diverted to buy cars. The only way to avoid this trap is to stick to your budget guidelines and don't commit more than you have.

The best value in an automobile for most families is a good used car. The temptation to buy a new car is often motivated by the cheaper interest rates offered as part of a dealer's sales promotion. But the higher price of the car more than offsets any potential interest reduction.

Many used cars have extended warranties that can be assumed by purchasers, so even the advantages of a new car warranty are lessened.

I believe that for the miles driven, a good used car less than 3 years old beats the per-mile cost of a new car by at least 40 percent. The best buys in used cars are usually found by buying directly from the previous owners as opposed to buying from a used-car lot. By buying directly from the owner, you can learn the history of the car and usually negotiate the best possible price.

A young pastor and his wife called one evening to ask for advice on what they could do about the two new cars they were leasing at a total cost of \$500 a month. On his salary as a pastor of a small church and her salary as a kindergarten teacher, they were sinking further into debt each month.

"Pastor," I said, "how in the world did you ever get talked into renting two new cars?" The story was a little different, but the result was the same.

He had a church member who was in the automobile business. The pastor desperately needed some reliable transportation for visitations, and this member negotiated the loan of a